
Teaching Statement in Secondary EFL Education

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“Education is not the filling of a pail, but the lighting of a fire.” W.B. Yeats’ words remind me of the responsibility of educators to ignite engagement with knowledge. Growing up in a low-resource context, I luckily discovered the fire of language not through rote repetition, but through meaningful interaction in the real life.

These experiences led me to teach and believe in moments that ignite fire of language. As a secondary EFL teacher for senior students in mainland China, I see my role as a window, showcasing the wider world and bridging my students with it.

Teaching Philosophy

I firmly believe students learn language most effectively by living it in meaningful contexts. Therefore, my teaching philosophy is grounded in progressivism and sociocultural theory, realized through Task-Based Language Teaching localized for senior secondary students in mainland China. Consistent with Vygotsky’s ideas of Zones of Proximal Development, I consider teachers as guides who reveal the world and offer timely scaffolding. As an EFL teacher, my primary goal is to develop not only language skills but also confident communicators who are critical, independent learners with cultural awareness, which will be achieved by the following principles.

○ **Step into students’ shoes**

Knowing students is the first stage in my teaching practice. By stepping into their shoes, I understand their contexts, preexisting knowledge, motivations, and challenges, allowing me to design activities that resonate. I distribute anonymous surveys at different stages to adapt my teaching and connect with students outside class. When I discovered a student was an NBA fan, I invited him to co-design a warm-up quiz about basketball stars for a reading on Stephen Curry. This made the lesson more engaging for all while accomplishing learning goals.

○ **Create a supportive learning community**

A positive classroom environment where all students feel valued and supported is essential for effective learning. I always welcome students’ thoughts and mistakes, stating that they are part of language learning. To encourage students with low proficiency or confidence, take for example, I designed writing materials that show text analysis process, provide sentence structures, and summarize common errors. Below the writing materials every time, I included self-reflective questions and peer review blankets to guide students and build their confidence. The approaches productively make students feel supported and challenged.

○ **Cater to individual needs**

Though in a pretty large class setting, I consider differentiated instruction essential. To address

individual differences, I offer compulsory and alternative assignments, open office hours for support. For each students, I create personalized student handbooks with AI tools, to record their progress while set personal goal together. Additionally, I differentiate instruction and provide time for individual, pair, and group reflection. Group work is structured both in and outside classroom so that students could learn from peers. For instance, I incorporate reading circles as group assignments, where students serve as different roles (translator, summarizer, etc.), sharing ideas and questions while developing critical thinking and independent learning abilities.

- **Integrate English language skills with core competencies**

To prepare confident communicators, my teaching goes beyond language skills to include critical thinking, learning ability, and cultural awareness. Through TBLT, students engage in authentic problem-solving tasks that connect language to social realities. For example, after the reading about *Longji Rice Terraces*, I formed a “Model Standing Committee” where students collected information and played roles as farmers, Bureaus of Natural Resources, Agriculture and Rural Affairs to debate tourism development. Through such projects, students practice language skills while thinking critically about real-world issues and developing independent learning abilities.

- **Revealing Connections through Big Ideas and diversified materials**

Students invest more when they understand why learning matters and address challenges affecting them. By connecting language learning to topic-specific concepts and real-world issues, students see the relevance and value of their learning. I incorporate big ideas by linking unit topics to students’ interests and experiences, activating prior knowledge. Additionally, to provide real life situations and cater to different learning styles, I implement diversified materials, like AIGC videos, news reports. Once learning about Dunhuang Mogao Grottoes, I incorporated the AR scenery into the lesson, vividly displaying the location and looking of caves and scrolls, which are originally words lying in the textbook.

■ Teaching Reflection and Future Plans

In my past practices, after each unit or open class, I reviewed lesson plans and recordings to see how activities support student growth and engagement, and built on my reflection notes. These experiences help me measure student progress and further complete the design. Moving forward, I will continue working on curriculum and teaching design while welcoming feedback from students and colleagues, to help every student find their fire.